



DEVESH SHAKYA, *43* ▶

| SP | *Etah, UP*

Devesh defeated the BJP's two-time Etah MP Rajveer Singh, son of the late Uttar Pradesh chief minister and veteran Lodh leader Kalyan Singh. A law graduate and non-Yadav OBC leader, he is also considered as someone with grassroots connections in the Etah belt. Devesh has also been successful in aligning the non-Yadav OBCs—especially the Shakya voters (part of the larger Kushwaha community) who are considered important in the Etah belt—with the SP, which was probably why Akhilesh handed him the poll ticket.



▲ BHUPATHI RAJU SRINIVASA VARMA, *56*

| BJP | *Narsapuram, Andhra Pradesh*

A former activist of the CPI's All India Students Federation, he was part of the ABVP and the RSS, before enlisting in the BJP. Has helped the party mobilise mass protests on various issues. Defeated the YSRCP's Umabala Guduri.



▲ AJENDRA SINGH LODHI, *53*

| SP | *Hamirpur, UP*

A grassroots OBC leader from the Bundelkhand belt, he's been effective in building up the SP cadre in Hamirpur. Defeated the BJP's Pushpendra Singh Chandel.



◀ RAJKUMAR SANGWAN, 64

| RLD | *Baghpat, UP*

The senior RLD spokesperson is considered close to party chairman Jayant Chaudhary's family and has served in various key positions. He has also focussed on building the party's cadre base in west UP. A PhD in philosophy, he defeated the SP's Amarpal.

SANATAN PANDEY, *61* ▶

| SP | *Ballia, UP*

Considered a trusted aide of the late Samajwadi Party founder Mulayam Singh Yadav, he won the 2007 UP assembly polls from Chilkahar before unsuccessfully contesting the 2019 Lok Sabha polls. He has retained grassroots connect, which is believed to have worked in his favour. He defeated the BJP's Neeraj Shekhar, son of the late PM Chandra Shekhar in the family's home bastion.



– By Amarnath K. Menon, Prashant Srivastava and Jumana Shah